

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Retail and E-Commerce English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For retail managers, e-commerce teams, merchandising staff, store operations leaders, fulfillment teams, customer service managers, marketplace sellers, and growth operators.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Merchandising and Assortment Planning

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

02 Pricing, Promotions, and Margin

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

03 Inventory, Allocation, and Replenishment

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

04 Fulfillment, Shipping, and Returns

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

05 Conversion, UX, and Digital Analytics

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

06 Marketplace and Vendor Management

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

07 Customer Service and Escalations

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

08 Store Operations and Omnichannel Execution

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Merchandising and Assortment Planning

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

Two product ranges have similar sales revenue, but one sells through more slowly and requires larger markdowns.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: assortment, SKU, sell-through, gross margin.

Model response

The revenue totals are similar, but their inventory and markdown patterns differ. Let's compare sell-through and margin as well before deciding which range is performing better.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. A - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 · Conversations

1. Similar revenue, different sell-through - Fictional assortment review: two ranges have similar revenue over the same season, but range B sells through more slowly and needs larger markdowns; costs are not fully assessed.
2. Fewer SKUs or broader choice? - Separate fictional assortment case: range A offers six SKUs and B twelve, with the same planned opening stock value. Customer-demand evidence and replenishment costs are incomplete.

3. A high margin percentage can hide slow movement - Separate fictional range comparison: A has a higher stated gross-margin percentage but slower sell-through than B; identical-period total margin contribution has not been calculated.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Online variety versus store display limits

Two fictional assortment proposals use the same purchase budget. A places eight items in stores and online; B places four in stores and eight online. Store display capacity is limited, and customer-demand evidence is incomplete. Compare the channel tradeoff.

Role A: Merchandising planner: distinguish store breadth from online availability under the same budget.

Role B: Store manager: explain the display constraint and ask what demand information is missing.

Possible opening: Both proposals use the same budget, but they offer different levels of choice in stores.

Success checks

- Compare the same budget and channel scope.
- Keep online listing distinct from local stock.
- Identify missing demand evidence before recommending an allocation.

Add a complication: The manager assumes online availability guarantees immediate store pickup.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Pricing, Promotions, and Margin

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A promotion increases units sold by 20%, while the selling price falls by 15%. A team member assumes profit must have increased.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: markdown, promotion, gross margin, cannibalization.

Model response

Higher unit sales do not by themselves show higher profit. We need the price, cost, and mix effects. I'll separate volume growth from the margin question in the promotion review.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. More units do not establish higher profit - Fictional promotion review: units sold rise 20% and selling price falls 15%, compared with the same base period; costs and sales-mix effects are not supplied.
2. Featured sales rise while neighboring items fall - Separate fictional promotion case: a featured SKU's sales rise while neighboring SKUs decline; total category results and causal effects remain unassessed.

3. A markdown clears stock but may reduce contribution - Separate fictional clearance review: a markdown reduces remaining stock from 60 units to 10; associated margin and costs have not been calculated.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Redemption counts do not prove incremental demand

A fictional coupon campaign records 200 redemptions. No comparison group or analysis of customers who would have bought anyway is available. Discuss what the count shows and what remains unknown about the promotion's effect.

Role A: Promotions analyst: separate coupon usage from additional demand and profit.

Role B: Marketing manager: ask what evidence could support a stronger claim.

Possible opening: Two hundred coupons were redeemed, but that doesn't tell us how many purchases were additional.

Success checks

- State the verified redemption count.
- Avoid equating redemptions with new customers or incremental sales.
- Request a suitable comparison and margin analysis.

Add a complication: The manager wants to call every redemption a newly acquired customer.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Inventory, Allocation, and Replenishment

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A product is available in one warehouse but out of stock in several stores. The website uses a single national inventory total.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: allocation, replenishment, stockout, inventory turn.

Model response

The national total hides local shortages. I'll report availability by location and check the replenishment status so customers and store teams receive a more useful update.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. C - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. B - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 • Conversations

1. National stock does not mean store availability - Fictional inventory update: a product is available in one warehouse but unavailable in several stores; the website displays a single national total.
2. Allocated is not yet dispatched - Separate fictional replenishment case: 24 units are allocated to Store 6, but the warehouse dispatch record remains open.

3. The stock count is complete, the discrepancy is not - Separate fictional inventory case: a store count finds 17 units while the system shows 20; a discrepancy review is open and no adjustment is approved.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Received units await the availability check

A fictional store receives ten units of a product, but the receiving check is incomplete and the available-to-sell status is not confirmed. Staff ask whether pickup orders can be promised. Give a precise progress update.

Role A: Receiving coordinator: distinguish physical arrival from completed availability checks.

Role B: Store service lead: ask which status remains open before discussing pickup availability.

Possible opening: Ten units have arrived, but the receiving check and available-to-sell status are still pending.

Success checks

- State the received quantity.
- Keep sale availability unconfirmed.
- Request a verified receiving update without promising pickup timing.

Add a complication: A manager wants to promise collection in fifteen minutes without an accepted completion estimate.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Fulfillment, Shipping, and Returns

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

CASE

A customer receives an estimated delivery date that has already passed. The carrier has not confirmed a new arrival time.

Teach this move

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Vocabulary to check: fulfillment, SLA, return rate, carrier.

Model response

I'm sorry the estimated date has passed. I am checking the shipment status with the responsible team. I'll give you the next verified update and explain the available options under our service process.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Second-round challenge

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Language-check answers

1. B - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear. This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.
2. A - The corrected date and the current confirmation status. A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

05 • Conversations

1. The delivery estimate was not a guarantee - Fictional fulfillment case: a delivery estimate has passed; the carrier has not confirmed a new arrival time. A retail service lead speaks with a business buyer.
2. A return label was mistaken for a refund - Separate fictional returns rehearsal: a supervisor practices a customer-facing correction with a returns coordinator. A return label is issued, but an email calls the refund

complete; receipt, review, and refund status are not established.

3. A split shipment was described as complete - Separate fictional order case: one of two parcels is delivered; the second has no confirmed arrival time. The retailer's message says the whole order arrived.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Collection scheduled, not completed

A fictional retailer's message says a return was collected, but the record only shows a pickup appointment booked. The carrier's collection result is unknown. Correct the status in a call with a business customer.

Role A: Returns service lead: acknowledge the mistaken completed status and explain the verified appointment status.

Role B: Business customer coordinator: ask how the actual collection will be checked.

Possible opening: Our message incorrectly said collected; the record only confirms that a pickup appointment was booked.

Success checks

- Separate appointment, collection, and receipt.
- Acknowledge the inaccurate message.
- Agree a carrier-status check without inventing progress.

Add a complication: The customer asks you to declare the return received at the warehouse as well.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Conversion, UX, and Digital Analytics

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

Checkout conversion falls after a redesign, but payment outages occurred in the same period.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: conversion rate, funnel, cart abandonment, A/B test.

Model response

The decline overlaps with both the redesign and payment outages. We should investigate those factors before attributing the change to the design alone.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. A redesign and an outage overlap - Fictional digital-retail analysis: checkout conversion fell after a redesign, while payment outages occurred in the same period; causal contribution is unassessed.
2. A tracking change can alter the denominator - Separate fictional analytics case: a tracking revision changes which sessions are counted, and reported conversion rate rises; purchase totals have not yet been reconciled.

3. Five usability sessions do not establish a sales uplift - Separate fictional UX review: four of five test participants finish a prototype checkout; no live sales experiment has been conducted.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Mobile traffic changed during the comparison

A fictional store's overall conversion rate falls while the share of mobile traffic rises. Device-level rates and payment status have not been compared. Discuss why the aggregate decline does not yet identify a cause.

Role A: Ecommerce analyst: separate the observed total change from the untested traffic-mix explanation.

Role B: Product manager: ask for the device-level and payment checks needed for a fair comparison.

Possible opening: Overall conversion fell while the traffic mix changed, but we haven't established which factors explain the decline.

Success checks

- State the observed changes without asserting causation.
- Avoid assumptions about shopper behavior.
- Request comparable device-level and payment evidence.

Add a complication: The manager wants to blame mobile shoppers rather than examine the data.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Marketplace and Vendor Management

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A vendor scorecard records a high defect rate but does not define the denominator or reporting period.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: marketplace, vendor scorecard, SLA, defect rate.

Model response

Could you confirm whether the rate is based on units, orders, or inspected samples, and for which period? We need a consistent basis before discussing vendor performance.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. C - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Define the defect-rate denominator - Fictional vendor review: a scorecard calls a defect rate high but omits the denominator and reporting period; no contractual breach is established.
2. Request comparable dispatch evidence - Separate fictional marketplace case: a vendor reports orders dispatched, while the retailer's scorecard uses carrier acceptance; the reporting period is the same.

3. A corrective proposal needs a named response - Separate fictional vendor case: a marketplace requested a plan for repeated packaging defects; the vendor replied we will improve without actions or ownership.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A vendor scorecard mixes canceled and shipped orders

A fictional scorecard's order count includes cancellations, but its defect count concerns shipped orders. The intended denominator is unconfirmed. Request the calculation definition and matching counts before the vendor review.

Role A: Vendor analyst: explain the possible mismatch and request the intended basis.

Role B: Supplier reporting lead: obtain the source definitions without assuming all cancellations are defects.

Possible opening: Could you confirm whether the denominator should include canceled orders, since the defect count concerns shipped orders?

Success checks

- Identify the population mismatch.
- Request a justified, consistent denominator.
- Avoid selecting definitions solely to improve the result.

Add a complication: The supplier proposes choosing whichever denominator gives the lower rate.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Customer Service and Escalations

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

A customer requests a return outside the stated policy. The representative can explain approved options but cannot invent an exception.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: return policy, goodwill credit, chargeback, customer lifetime value.

Model response

I understand why you are asking. Let me explain the available options under the policy and check whether the appropriate team can review your circumstances. I cannot promise an exception before that review.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. B - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. A - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

05 · Conversations

1. An outside-policy return needs review - Fictional retailer case: a business buyer requests a return outside the stated policy. The representative may explain approved options or request exception review, but cannot grant an exception.

2. A partial replacement is available under the case offer - Separate fictional case: an authorized service offer permits replacing one missing item now or waiting for a complete two-item bundle; bundle availability is unconfirmed and the buyer has not chosen.

3. A review call or an asynchronous status response - Separate fictional escalation case: a buyer wants an immediate senior review, but the service team can offer a booked review call or a status response after case review; timing must be agreed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An alternative color needs buyer acceptance

A fictional retailer may offer an in-stock green replacement or seek approval for another option. The ordered blue version is unavailable with no confirmed replenishment date. The buyer prefers blue. Negotiate a bounded next step without substituting automatically.

Role A: Customer service lead: offer green or an authorized review, stating the unconfirmed blue timing.

Role B: Business buyer: choose whether to accept green or wait for the review without promising your team's approval.

Possible opening: Green is available under the approved replacement offer; blue has no confirmed replenishment date.

Success checks

- State the verified color option and unknown timing.
- Obtain consent rather than substitute silently.
- Keep any additional offer subject to authorized review.

Add a complication: The buyer asks you to reserve an unconfirmed blue unit and guarantee its arrival.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Store Operations and Omnichannel Execution

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

CASE

A pickup order is marked ready online, but staff cannot find one item. The next shift needs to resolve the discrepancy.

Teach this move

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Vocabulary to check: BOPIS, inventory accuracy, queue, labor model.

Model response

The order is marked ready, but one item has not been located. Please verify the stock and update the order status through our process before confirming pickup to the customer.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Second-round challenge

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Language-check answers

1. A - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check. It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.
2. C - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct? This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

05 • Conversations

1. Ready online, one item missing - Fictional store shift handoff: a pickup order is marked ready online, but staff cannot find one item; the next shift must investigate and coordinate the customer update.
2. A reserved item has not reached the pickup shelf - Separate fictional omnichannel handoff: an item is reserved for pickup, but transfer from the stockroom is not confirmed; the receiving shift accepts follow-up.
3. A store transfer needs receiving acknowledgment - Separate fictional store-operations case: Store A records a transfer dispatched to Store B, but B has not acknowledged receipt; a pickup customer awaits a status update.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 • Say it: second scenario | A pickup cancellation and a shelf label disagree

A fictional order is recorded as canceled online, but its bag remains on the pickup shelf with an active label. The item-release and stock-status checks are uncompleted. Hand over the discrepancy without giving collection or restocking instructions.

Role A: Outgoing store coordinator: identify the cancellation and label mismatch and request accepted follow-up.

Role B: Incoming supervisor: accept the authorized status check and confirm who will update the service team.

Possible opening: The order is canceled online, but its shelf label still appears active and the stock-status check remains open.

Success checks

- Preserve the canceled status and physical-label discrepancy.
- Use the authorized verification process before any release decision.
- Confirm ownership of the check and service update.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to hand over the bag solely because the customer presents the old pickup message.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Retail and E-Commerce English

Professional audience: retail managers, e-commerce teams, merchandising staff, store operations leaders, fulfillment teams, customer service managers, marketplace sellers, and growth operators

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Merchandising and Assortment Planning

Original fictional case: Two product ranges have similar sales revenue, but one sells through more slowly and requires larger markdowns.

Language workshop: Explain a fair comparison

Communication goal: Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

Language guidance: Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Both options ..., but ... / Option A ..., whereas option B ... / The comparison depends on ...

Vocabulary: assortment: The selection of products offered by a retailer. / SKU: Stock keeping unit: an identifier for a distinct inventory item. / sell-through: The proportion of available stock sold during a defined period using a stated calculation. / gross margin: Revenue minus cost of goods sold, expressed as an amount or a percentage of revenue.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The revenue totals are similar, but their inventory and markdown patterns differ. Let's compare sell-through and margin as well before deciding which range is performing better.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Retail and E-Commerce English

Professional audience: retail managers, e-commerce teams, merchandising staff, store operations leaders, fulfillment teams, customer service managers, marketplace sellers, and growth operators

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Merchandising and Assortment Planning

Original fictional case: Two product ranges have similar sales revenue, but one sells through more slowly and requires larger markdowns.

Language workshop: Explain a fair comparison

Communication goal: Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

Language guidance: Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Both options ..., but / Option A ..., whereas option B / The comparison depends on

Vocabulary: assortment: The selection of products offered by a retailer. / SKU: Stock keeping unit: an identifier for a distinct inventory item. / sell-through: The proportion of available stock sold during a defined period using a stated calculation. / gross margin: Revenue minus cost of goods sold, expressed as an amount or a percentage of revenue.

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Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The revenue totals are similar, but their inventory and markdown patterns differ. Let's compare sell-through and margin as well before deciding which range is performing better.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level